When Iraqi forces massed on Kuwait's border with Saudi Arabia, many feared that Iraq might seize the Saudi oilfields, the biggest in the world, and thus gain control of more than half of the world's oilfields. When the King of Saudi Arabia requested that the USA send military forces to defend his country in case of attack, the Americans were quick to oblige. Over a period of a few months, there was a build-up of naval, land and air forces.

Although some Arab states, like Jordan, preferred an 'Arab' solution to the problem, the majority fully supported the deadline which the UN delivered to Iraq: withdraw from Kuwait by 15 January 1991 or face military force.

Saddam predicted the 'mother of all battles' and it started when the USA led a coalition of 34 countries into action. About 600,000 troops had been assembled in the deserts of Saudi Arabia. Most were American but Britain and France also sent large forces. Most significant of all was that many Arab countries such as Egypt and Syria sent troops, as did other Muslim countries such as Pakistan and Bangladesh. Saddam would not be able to claim that this was a Western crusade against the Arabs and Islam.

The Gulf War, January–March 1991

The war to liberate Kuwait became known as the Gulf War as Kuwait was situated at the head of the Persian Gulf (see the map on page 131). The fighting started with an air assault, largely by US forces, on Iraq in January 1991. The targets were not just military ones but airports, bridges, factories and roads. The aerial bombardment lasted five weeks. Saddam dug in, hoping world opinion would turn against the war. His forces fired Scud missiles into Israel in the hope that this would cause a split between the West and their Arab allies. The US persuaded the Israelis not to retaliate and the Arab members of the US-led coalition stayed firm.

In February the ground attack began. The Iraqis were driven out of Kuwait but not before they had torched the oil wells, causing a huge ecological disaster in the Gulf. Then US-led forces entered Iraq. The US President called on the Kurds in the north and the Shiites in the south to rise up and overthrow Saddam. They both responded, but they lacked arms and received no support from coalition forces. In the Shia south about 50,000 were killed by Saddam's forces and similar reprisals were expected in the Kurdish north. However, media coverage rallied world opinion and forced the USA and Britain to act. The Americans and British established **'no-fly zones'**, which prevented Saddam regaining control of the north. A 'safe haven' was created for the Kurds who have been effectively in control of their areas ever since.

Key question
What was the outcome of the Gulf War?

Key date
First Gulf War: January–March 1991

Key term
'No-fly zones'
These were areas in the Kurdish north and, later, the Shiite south where Iraqi planes were forbidden to fly. They were designed to protect these areas from attack by Saddam's army. The zones were policed by US and British planes which flew from bases in Turkey or from aircraft carriers in the Gulf.